TOP SECRET

A PRINTABLE CHRISTMAS ESCAPE ROOM

Operation: Reindeer Rescue

Dasher has the Northern Lights Flu, and a mischievous elf has hidden the cure. Can your team crack the codes before midnight?



AGES 11–14 | 2–8 PLAYERS | 45–60 MIN

Earth & Wonder

FOR THE GAME MASTER

Setup Guide

About 10 minutes to prepare. No locks or props needed.

YOU'LL NEED

This printed kit · 3 envelopes (or folded sheets of paper) · Pens or pencils · Scissors (only for the optional Shift Wheel) · A timer

Before the game

1. Print every page. Keep the **Answer Key** and **Hint Cards** for yourself.
2. Label 3 envelopes: **Envelope 2: Candy Kitchen Evidence**, **Envelope 3: Dasher's Medical File** and **Envelope 4: The Medicine Chest**.
3. Put Puzzle 2 and the Shift Wheel in Envelope 2, Puzzle 3 in Envelope 3, and Puzzle 4 in Envelope 4.
4. Set the Victory Page and Agent Certificates aside for the big finish.
5. Cut out the Hint Cards and set a 60-minute timer.

How the locks work

Each envelope stays locked until players tell you the correct answer. Right answer? Hand over the next envelope. Wrong answer? Announce **"ACCESS DENIED!"** in your most dramatic voice and let them try again.

PUZZLE 1 Alibi → **PUZZLE 2** Cipher → **PUZZLE 3** Chart → **PUZZLE 4** Final Lock → **VICTORY!** Dasher saved

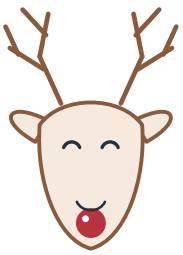
Running the game

To start: read the Mission Briefing aloud (or let a player read it), hand out Puzzle 1 and start the clock.

Hints: if players are stuck for 5 minutes, offer the next Hint Card. For extra challenge, add 2 minutes to their time for each hint.

Teams: for 6–8 players, print 2 copies of each puzzle so everyone can work at once.

Digital play: the answer boxes are fillable, so older players can type directly into the PDF on a tablet or computer.



FILE #1224

NORTH POLE INTELLIGENCE AGENCY

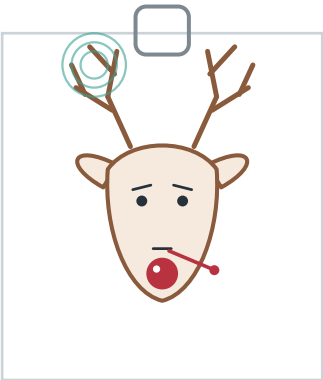
CLASSIFIED · LEVEL 5 CLEARANCE · EYES ONLY

TOP SECRET

Operation: Reindeer Rescue

Agents,

At 6:00 PM tonight, Dasher collapsed during flight practice. His antlers are glowing green, his nose won't stop sparkling, and every time he sneezes, it snows indoors.



PATIENT: DASHER

Diagnosis: **NORTHERN LIGHTS FLU.**

Without the antidote, Dasher can't fly. Without Dasher, the sleigh can't leave the ground.

There's one problem. The antidote formula is missing. Security footage shows **JAX**, the workshop's most mischievous elf, sneaking out of the Antidote Lab with the formula tucked under his hat. Jax claims it's "just a harmless prank." He has hidden the formula behind a trail of puzzles and locked the medicine in an unbreakable chest.

YOUR MISSION:

1. Crack Jax's alibi and find where he hid his first clue.
2. Decode his secret message from the Antidote Lab.
3. Search Dasher's medical chart for the vault code.
4. Break the final lock and deliver the antidote.

If Dasher can't fly by **MIDNIGHT**, Christmas is **CANCELLED.**

No pressure, agents. The whole world is counting on you.

Commander Ivy Frost
North Pole Intelligence Agency

This message will self-destruct in 60 minutes. (Not really. But hurry.)

TIME REMAINING

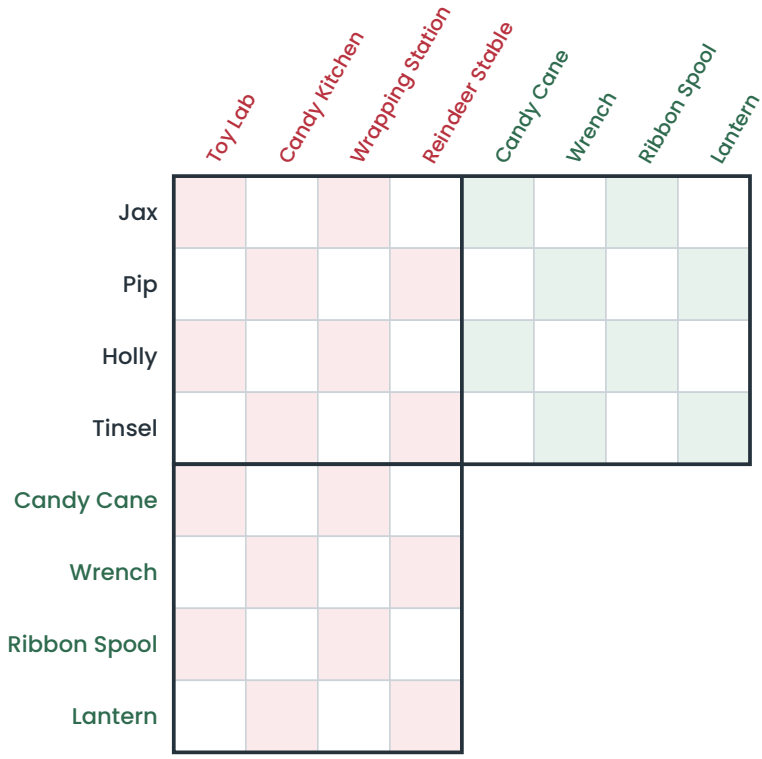
60:00

PUZZLE 1 · EVIDENCE FILE A

Jax's Alibi

Four elves. Four rooms. Four items. One sneaky liar.

Four elves were working in four different parts of the workshop tonight, each holding a different item. Use the clues to fill in the grid. Mark ✓ for yes and ✗ for no. Once you know where Jax was, check the Security Door Log to find out exactly **when** he hid his first clue.



THE CLUES

1. Security confirms that neither Pip nor Holly set foot in the Reindeer Stable or the Candy Kitchen tonight.
2. Whoever was holding the wrench was in the Toy Lab tightening robot bolts, and that elf's name does **not** begin with H.
3. The elf in the Reindeer Stable was feeding Comet something sweet and striped. It wasn't Jax. He's allergic to reindeer fur.
4. Holly is scared of the dark, but she was **not** the one carrying a light.

SECURITY DOOR LOG

Each door was opened exactly once, by the elf who worked inside. Jax hid his clue the moment he walked through his door.

Toy Lab	8:15 PM
Candy Kitchen	9:47 PM
Wrapping Station	10:30 PM
Reindeer Stable	11:05 PM

LOCK 1

Jax was in the _____ at _____ holding a _____

Tell the Game Master the location and time to unlock Envelope 2.

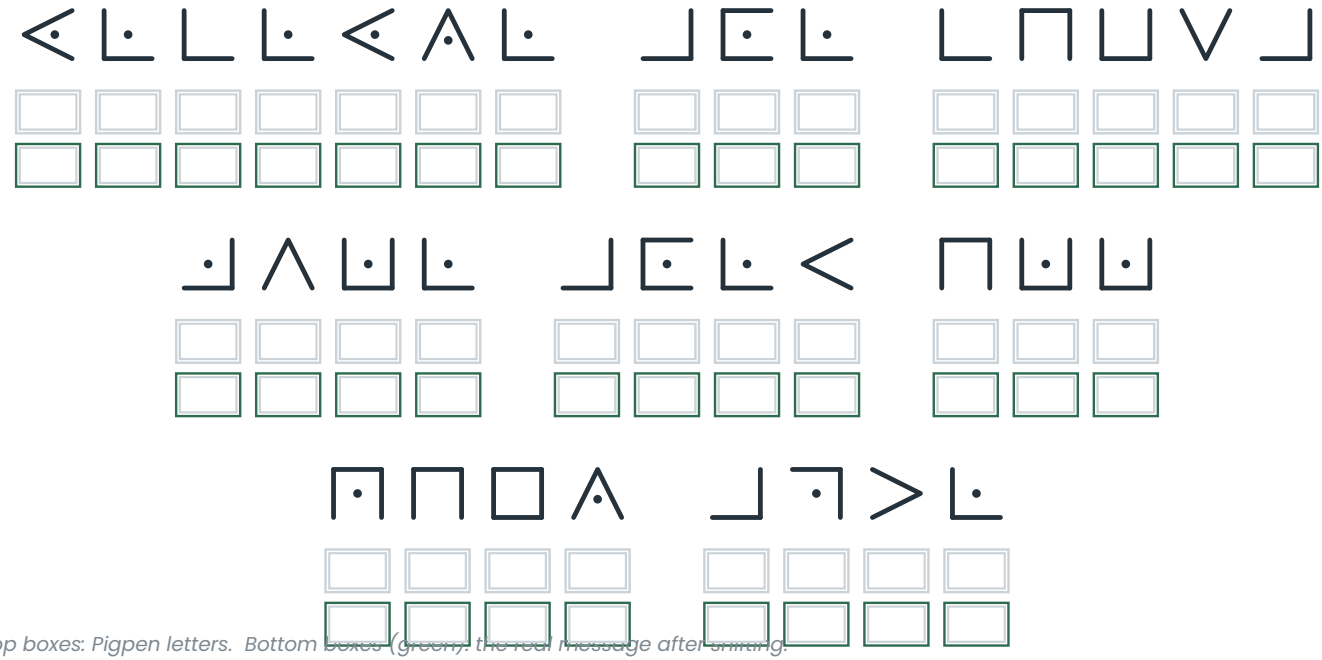
PUZZLE 2 · EVIDENCE FILE B

The Antidote Lab Cipher

Found inside a gingerbread oven in the Candy Kitchen.

> *"Bet you can't read this! My lantern lit the way to my hiding spot. Count the letters in what I carried, then walk the alphabet BACKWARDS that many steps. Ha!" — J.*

STEP 1: PIGPEN LETTERS STEP 2: SHIFT BACKWARDS MESSAGE



Top boxes: Pigpen letters. Bottom boxes (green): the real message after shifting.

LAB DECODER: PIGPEN KEY



How to read a symbol: each symbol is the shape of the lines around a letter's space. A dot means the second grid or second X. For example, a line on the right and bottom is A; a full square is E; a V shape is S.

LOCK 2

Jax's message: _____

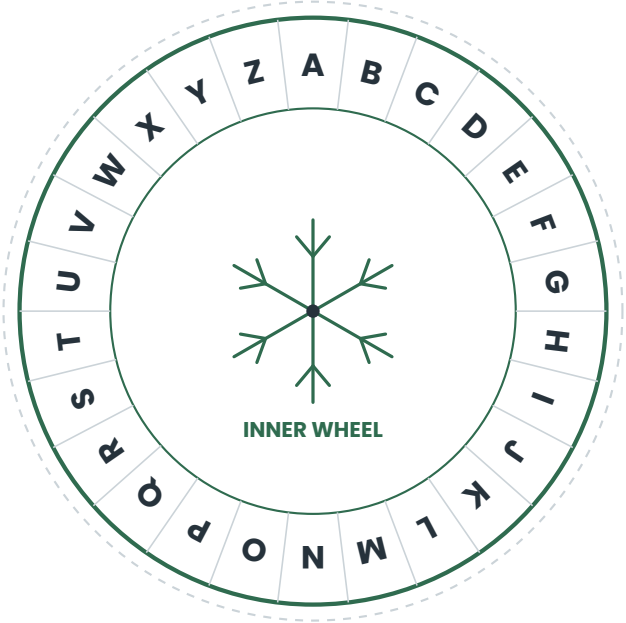
OPTIONAL CUT-OUT · PUZZLE 2

Shift Wheel

Cut out both circles. Place the small one on top and push a pencil through the centre to spin.



OUTER WHEEL



INNER WHEEL

PUZZLE 3 · EVIDENCE FILE C

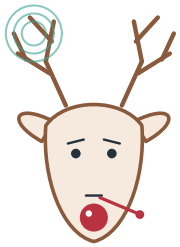
Dasher's Medical Chart

Patient: DASHER · Condition: Northern Lights Flu · Status: CRITICAL

Jax hid the vault code inside Dasher's symptom scan, then covered it with medical words. Solve each riddle to find the words, then circle them in the grid. Words run in all 8 directions, including backwards and diagonally, and some share letters. The **15 leftover letters**, read left to right and top to bottom, spell the vault code.

T	P	E	Z	E	E	N	S	A	W
R	E	I	N	D	E	E	R	D	H
S	P	C	O	E	I	O	M	A	O
L	P	O	G	H	R	E	Y	S	O
E	E	C	T	U	D	D	F	H	V
I	R	O	A	I	N	B	E	E	E
G	M	A	C	A	E	S	V	R	S
H	I	I	C	L	L	O	E	N	E
A	N	T	L	E	R	S	R	F	I
E	T	O	D	I	T	N	A	V	E

SYMPTOM SCAN



PATIENT PROFILE

1. Our patient, and the fastest flyer on the team.
_ _ _ _ _ _ (6)

2. The kind of animal our patient is.
_ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ (8)

3. The branches on top of his head.
_ _ _ _ _ _ _ (7)

4. His four feet.
_ _ _ _ _ _ (6)

5. What he'll pull on Christmas Eve if he recovers.
_ _ _ _ _ _ (6)

6. The sleigh's smaller, snowy cousin.
_ _ _ _ (4)

SYMPTOMS

7. The flu's fancy name comes from this sky-glowing light show.
_ _ _ _ _ _ (6)

8. A high temperature.
_ _ _ _ _ (5)

9. Achoo!
_ _ _ _ _ _ (6)

10. Jingle, jingle… this rings in his ears.
_ _ _ _ (4)

TREATMENT PLAN

11. The cure that Jax stole.
_ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ (8)

12. What doctors give to make you better.
_ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ (8)

13. Cool, striped and minty: soothes a sore throat.
_ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ (10)

14. A warm, chocolatey drink for the patient.
_ _ _ _ _ (5)

15. The sweet stuff on the tree, shaped like a cane.
_ _ _ _ _ (5)

LOCK 3

LEFTOVER LETTERS: ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

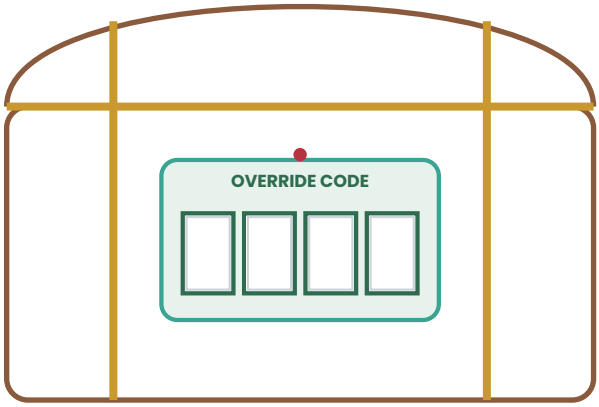
VAULT CODE: ☐☐☐☐

PUZZLE 4 · EVIDENCE FILE D

The Final Antidote Lock

It's 11:52 PM. One wrong digit and the chest locks for 100 years.





"Okay, okay, you're good. But are you good enough? Only an agent who followed my message EXACTLY can open this chest. One wrong digit and it locks for 100 years. (That might be an exaggeration.)" — J.

Agent Mission Log

Where and when Jax hid his first clue (Puzzle 1):

Jax's secret message (Puzzle 2):

The vault code (Puzzle 3):

Work it out

Step 1: _____ = _____

Step 2: _____ = _____

CALCULATIONS

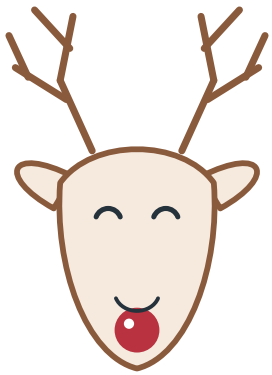
FINAL LOCK

Tell the Game Master your 4-digit override code. Hurry, it's almost midnight!

OVERRIDE ACCEPTED

Mission Accomplished!

Dasher is Saved!



The antidote worked! Dasher's antlers stopped glowing, his nose stopped sparkling, and he's already doing practice loops over the workshop. Santa's sleigh is cleared for takeoff, and Christmas is officially back on. As for Jax? He's been assigned to clean the reindeer stables until New Year's. (He's still allergic.)

Mission time:

Hints used:

CASE CLOSED

The North Pole Intelligence Agency thanks you for your service.

NORTH POLE INTELLIGENCE AGENCY

Certificate of Bravery

This certifies that Agent

successfully completed **Operation: Reindeer Rescue**, cracked Jax's codes and saved Christmas.

DATE

COMMANDER IVY FROST

NORTH POLE INTELLIGENCE AGENCY

Certificate of Bravery

This certifies that Agent

successfully completed **Operation: Reindeer Rescue**, cracked Jax's codes and saved Christmas.

DATE

COMMANDER IVY FROST

FOR THE GAME MASTER

Hint Cards (1 of 2)

Cut out. Give one hint at a time, starting with Hint 1.

PUZZLE 1 · HINT 1

★

Start with Clue 1. It rules out two rooms for two elves at once. Mark those first.

PUZZLE 1 · HINT 2

★

In Clue 2, only two elves could be in the Toy Lab. Which one doesn't start with H?

PUZZLE 1 · HINT 3

★

Once you know who's in the Reindeer Stable (Clue 3), Jax has only one room left. Check that room's time in the Door Log.

PUZZLE 2 · HINT 1

★

Each symbol is the shape of the lines around a letter's space in the key. A dot means the second grid or second X.

PUZZLE 2 · HINT 2

★

Nonsense letters are normal. There's a second layer! What was Jax carrying in Puzzle 1?

PUZZLE 2 · HINT 3

★

LANTERN has 7 letters. Move each letter 7 places back: Y becomes R, L becomes E.

PUZZLE 3 · HINT 1

★

Solve all the riddles first. The number in brackets is how many letters each word has.

PUZZLE 3 · HINT 2

★

Words go backwards and diagonally, and some letters belong to two words. Try ANTIDOTE backwards along the bottom row.

PUZZLE 3 · HINT 3

★

The leftover letters spell four number words. The first starts in the very top-left corner.

FOR THE GAME MASTER

Hint Cards (2 of 2)

Cut out. Give one hint at a time, starting with Hint 1.

PUZZLE 4 · HINT 1

★

Jax's message from Puzzle 2 is your instructions. Do the steps in order.

PUZZLE 4 · HINT 2

★

To reverse a number, write its digits backwards: 1234 becomes 4321.

PUZZLE 4 · HINT 3

★

Jax's time is 9:47. Drop the colon to get 947, and add it to your reversed vault code.

FOR THE GAME MASTER ONLY

Answer Key

Keep this page hidden from players!

LOCK 1 — **Candy Kitchen at 9:47 PM**

Jax was holding the LANTERN. Give: Envelope 2

LOCK 2 — **REVERSE THE VAULT CODE THEN ADD JAXS TIME**

Pigpen gives YLCLYZL AOL CHBSA JVKL AOLU HKK QHEZ APTL, then shift back 7. Give: Envelope 3

LOCK 3 — **2815**

Leftover letters spell TWO EIGHT ONE FIVE. Give: Envelope 4

FINAL — **6129**

Reverse 2815 = 5182, then 5182 + 947 = 6129. Give: Victory Page

Puzzle 1 solution

Jax	Candy Kitchen	Lantern
Pip	Toy Lab	Wrench
Holly	Wrapping Station	Ribbon Spool
Tinsel	Reindeer Stable	Candy Cane

Puzzle 3 word locations (row, column)

1. DASHER (2,9) down
2. REINDEER (2,1) across
3. ANTLERS (9,1) across
4. HOOVES (2,10) down
5. SLEIGH (3,1) down
6. SLED (7,7) diagonal down-left
7. AURORA (6,4) diagonal up-right
8. FEVER (5,8) down
9. SNEEZE (1,8) backwards
10. BELL (6,7) diagonal down-left
11. ANTIDOTE (10,8) backwards
12. MEDICINE (3,8) diagonal down-left
13. PEPPERMINT (1,2) down
14. COCOA (3,3) down
15. CANDY (8,4) diagonal up-right

Common final-lock mistakes: adding without reversing (2815 + 947 = 3762) or using the wrong door time. Give a dramatic ACCESS DENIED and let them retry.